Name:Nidhi Patil
Cybersecurity Intern
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Task:18

VPN Fundamentals

Task 18: VPN Fundamentals

1. Objective

To study VPN architecture and understand how Virtual Private Networks protect network traffic over untrusted networks.

2. Introduction

A Virtual Private Network (VPN) is a technology that creates a secure, encrypted connection between a user's device and a VPN server or private network. This connection is called an encrypted tunnel. VPNs are used to improve privacy and provide secure remote connectivity.

3. VPN Architecture

The basic VPN architecture consists of the following components:

1. **User Device:** The computer or mobile device that initiates the connection.
2. **VPN Client:** Software that establishes the VPN connection.
3. **Encrypted Tunnel:** Protects traffic travelling between the VPN endpoints.

4. **VPN Server or Gateway:** Authenticates users and routes traffic according to the VPN configuration.
5. **Destination Network:** The private network or internet resource the user wants to access.

Architecture Diagram:

User Device → VPN Client → Encrypted Tunnel → VPN Server → Destination Network

4. How a VPN Protects Traffic

1. The user starts the VPN client.
2. The VPN system authenticates the user or device.
3. The client and server establish a secure connection.
4. The VPN encrypts the traffic covered by the connection.
5. The encrypted traffic passes through the untrusted network.
6. The VPN endpoint decrypts the traffic and forwards it to the destination.

Encryption helps prevent other people on the network from reading protected traffic while it travels through the tunnel.

5. Types of VPN

- **Remote-Access VPN:** Allows users to connect securely to an organization's network from another location.
- **Site-to-Site VPN:** Connects separate networks, such as two office branches.
- **Client-Based VPN:** Uses an application on the user's device.
- **SSL/TLS VPN:** Uses TLS-based technology for certain secure remote-access systems.

6. Advantages of VPN

- Protects covered network traffic through encryption.
- Improves security when using untrusted networks.
- Supports secure remote working.
- Connects geographically separated networks.
- Helps protect the confidentiality of data in transit.

7. VPN Limitations

- A VPN does not guarantee complete anonymity.
- The VPN provider may see certain connection information.
- Websites may still track users through cookies and account logins.
- A VPN does not automatically prevent malware or phishing.
- Security depends on correct configuration and the trustworthiness of the provider.

8. Security Best Practices

- Use a trusted or organization-approved VPN.
- Enable multi-factor authentication where available.
- Keep the VPN client and operating system updated.
- Continue using HTTPS for website connections.
- Avoid suspicious links and downloads.
- Review the VPN provider's privacy policy.

Interview Questions

Q1. What is a VPN?

A VPN is a Virtual Private Network that creates an encrypted connection between a device and a VPN endpoint or private network.

Q2. Why are VPNs used?

VPNs are used to protect network traffic on untrusted networks and provide secure remote access.

Q3. Does a VPN provide complete anonymity?

No. A VPN improves privacy but does not prevent every type of tracking or guarantee complete anonymity.

10. Result

The fundamentals of VPN architecture, encrypted tunnels, secure remote connectivity, VPN types, benefits, and limitations were studied.

11. Conclusion

A VPN is an important network-security technology that helps protect traffic across untrusted networks. However, it should be combined with strong authentication, HTTPS, updated software, and safe browsing practices.

Tools: Web Browser and Google Docs.

Note: This deliverable documents conceptual learning. No live VPN configuration or practical test is claimed.